

A DIFFICULT YEAR

NEHRU MEMORIAL LIBRARY

◀ REWIND



The country's economy took a beating after the 1971 war with Pakistan. With crop failure, a serious fall in food production and declining industrial growth, inflation skyrocketed and Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was forced to admit that it was "a very difficult year". India had to resort to loans from Japan, Britain, Canada and the World Bank even as it strove to increase the volume of bilateral trade with Russia. Diplomatic ties in the neighbourhood did not seem to be heading anywhere, with the prime minister rejecting Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's invitation to visit Pakistan.

UNSETTLING RESISTANCE

The Shanti Bahini guerrillas, members of the Chakma tribe, took up arms after Bangladesh rejected their demands for autonomy over a 5,500-sq mile region bordering India and Burma. They demanded the ouster of over three lakh people settled in their original homeland. There have been many armed clashes between the Shanti Bahini and the Bangladeshi military.



◀ DID YOU KNOW

Indira Gandhi broke with tradition, appointing Justice A.N. Ray chief justice of the Supreme Court, superseding three judges senior to him, triggering protests in the judiciary. Jayaprakash Narayan wrote to her asking whether these out-of-turn promotions were intended to make the Supreme Court "a creation of the government of the day". She answered that a mechanical adherence to the "seniority principle had led to an unduly high turnover of chief justices".

FIRST CUT

- The first national championship of women's cricket was conducted and Bombay emerged winner.
- The first all-woman police station in the country was set up at

Calicut in October.

- MP Govind Das was felicitated on November 21 in the Central Hall of Parliament, on completing 50 years as a parliamentarian, an unprecedented record then.

TANK TOP

The largest ship in the Indian merchant fleet, the supertanker *Jawaharlal Nehru*, with a dead weight tonnage of 88,000, was launched on February 4.